

HSE TOOLBOX TALK

WORKING AT HEIGHT

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This Toolbox Talk aims to reduce the risk of falls, falling objects and fatal injuries during work at height. Its scope covers all tasks where a person could fall from one level to another and be injured — including platforms, scaffolds, ladders, roofs, floor openings and equipment surfaces. Controls follow the ISO 45001:2018 hierarchy of controls and are applied together with a permit to work, a risk assessment and a pre-task site check before work begins.

KEY HAZARDS

1  FALL FROM HEIGHT	2  FRAGILE SURFACE	3  UNSAFE ACCESS	4  FALLING OBJECTS
5  MEWP / PLATFORM	6  WEATHER	7  ANCHOR FAILURE	8  SUSPENSION

CRITICAL VALUES TO VERIFY IN THE FIELD

1.8 m OSHA construction fall-protection trigger	1.2 m OSHA general-industry protection trigger	22 kN Anchor capacity required per worker
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REMEMBER — SERNEM

S

Stop and think

E

Evaluate the risk

R

Remove or reduce

N

Never assume

E

Ensure protection

M

Monitor and communicate

HSE TOOLBOX TALK

WORKING AT HEIGHT**STANDARDS AND FIELD REQUIREMENTS**

These references do more than define legal thresholds; they establish how a safe work-at-height system is built in the field. Where local law or the employer rule is stricter, always apply the higher standard.

OSHA 1926 SUBPART M**CONSTRUCTION FALL PROTECTION**

At 1.8 m (6 ft) or more, protect open edges, floor openings and work platforms with guardrails, covers or a personal fall-arrest system.

OSHA 1910 SUBPART D**WALKING-WORKING SURFACES**

In general industry, control fall exposure at 1.2 m (4 ft) or more. Verify access routes, ladders, openings and surface integrity before work starts.

ISO 45001:2018 · 8.1.2**HIERARCHY OF CONTROLS**

Eliminate work at height first. Then prioritise collective protection; personal fall arrest and PPE are the final lines of defence.

FIELD GOOD PRACTICE**COMPETENCE AND RESCUE**

Do not start without a tagged scaffold, verified anchor, pre-use equipment checks, a barricaded drop zone and a workable task-specific rescue plan.

MINIMUM EVIDENCE BEFORE START

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Approved permit to work and task-specific risk | ☐ Valid scaffold tag or platform inspection record |
| ☐ Anchor selection and required strength verification | ☐ Pre-use inspection of harness, lanyard / SRL |
| ☐ Drop-zone barricade and falling-object controls | ☐ Task-specific rescue plan, equipment and named |

SUPERVISOR DISCUSSION POINTS

- Can this task be completed from ground level or by a remote method?
- Why must collective protection come before personal fall arrest?
- After a fall, who will rescue the suspended person, how, and within what time?

SAFE WORK AT HEIGHT SETUP

Full guardrails · Overhead anchor · SRL · Tethered tools · Barricaded drop zone · Rescue ready

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CRITICAL CONTROL MEASURES (HIERARCHY OF CONTROLS)

1. AVOID (Elimination)

Avoid work at height where reasonably practicable. Prepare or pre-assemble the work at ground level, or use extendable / ground-operated equipment.

2. PREVENT FALLS (Collective protection)

Give priority to guardrails, working platforms, covers and barriers; use correctly erected scaffolds or a MEWP. Guardrail systems must be of adequate height and strength (OSHA: top rail ~1.07 m / 42 in).

3. MINIMISE CONSEQUENCES (Fall arrest)

Where collective protection is not practicable, use a safety net or a personal fall-arrest system: a full-body harness and an approved anchor ($\geq 5,000$ lb / ~ 22 kN per worker). Verify adequate fall clearance and swing-fall exposure.

4. ADMINISTRATIVE & PPE (Last resort)

Support controls with a permit to work, competent-person supervision, equipment inspection, a workable rescue plan and training. PPE alone is not adequate protection.

CRITICAL WARNING



NEVER work at height without inspected, suitable fall protection. Fall protection is required at 1.8 m (6 ft) or more in construction and at 1.2 m (4 ft) or more in general industry. Even a fall from a low height can be fatal.

SITE CHECKLIST (BEFORE STARTING WORK)

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Permit to work and risk assessment approved | ☐ Safe access and guardrails complete |
| ☐ Scaffold / platform inspected and tagged | ☐ Anchor points identified and strength verified |
| ☐ Harness and lanyard inspected | ☐ Area below barricaded, tools tethered |
| ☐ Weather, surface and lighting suitable | ☐ Rescue plan and equipment ready |
| ☐ Personnel competent and briefed | |

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ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

Project / Site:

Date:

Presented by:

Work area:

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
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10			
11			
12			